

First Viewing

It worked.

Not gracefully mind you. When the rings finally jerked into motion, my entire tower warped and shook for a moment and I thought I heard the trees outside start to moan. It passed as quickly as it began and for a brief moment I saw that pentagram formed by my humble runic discs matched in the heavens above. A thin wisp of silver light arced out from the core, subtle as a breath, and traced a line out of my observatory window and up towards the stars. Then projection bloomed. I nearly fell backwards. I had expected to peer around the constellations, to document the many more at the edges of our periphery, even to catch a fleeting glimpse of other worlds. Instead I saw... a tree.

Maybe it's just my Elven sensibilities, but it really resembled a tree. White latticework obscured my entire sight, branching through the void, nearer than any star has a right to be. It's boughs shimmered with the reflected light of the entire cosmos, each line pulsing with motion as I watched... faces? run up and down the branches like ants delivering leaf cuttings. I heard their voices singing in my teeth, resonating with my very being. I could not say if it was their memory, a prophecy, or some afterimage of something beyond the veil. I felt out of body. I watched myself stride over to the kill switch and terminate the experiment before returning to my physicality.

Despite my temporary loss of control, the lens worked as expected. I felt Pan's influence grasp at me and pass harmlessly through, like I wasn't even there, because I wasn't. Genius. I can definitively say that **I** am the first to look into the heavens and evade that suffocating dread. I've already scheduled my next observation. Whatever that tree is, it is close, maybe even *here*.